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Std VIII SOCIAL SCIENCE

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Democracy: Meaning and Scope

1.Define the following

Democracy - Democracy is not only a system of government but also a value. Democracy is built on the foundation of ideas such as Liberty, Equality, Justice, and Rights.

Constitutionalism- Democracy consists of governments that respect values and do not intrude upon them. This means that there are limits to the activities of the government. These limits are set by the constitution. Therefore, we can also call modern democracy a Constitutionalism.

2. The origin of the democratic system can be traced to?

☞ City-states of ancient Greece.

3.The word 'democracy,' meaning the power of the people, is derived from ?

⌑ It is derived from the Greek words 'Demos' meaning people, and 'Kratos' meaning power.

4. Examine the democratic system that existed in Athens ?

⌑ Athens had a culture that valued individual freedom and individual ability. All decisions concerning the state were made directly by the citizens.

⌑ Similarly, the military leaders and judges were directly elected by the people.

⌑ In this way, the democratic system in which the people directly participate in governance and law-making is called Direct Democracy.

⌑ However, its greatest limitation was that slaves and women did not participate in the democratic system that existed in Athens.

Direct Democracy: In the Contemporary World

5.Direct democracy in its complete form cannot be seen anywhere in the world today. However, some of its devices still exist in many democratic systems.What are the Devices of Direct Democracy?

Referendum	Recall	Plebiscite	Initiative
A process in which laws passed by the legislature are submitted to the people for their approval through voting.	The process of removing elected representatives from office when their performance is unsatisfactory. This is implemented by a written request from	A method used to ascertain the will of the people on very important public issues.	A way for people to directly intervene in law-making. They submit to the legislature either a draft or complete version of the law they desire.

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	a specified percentage of voters.		

6.Where does direct democratic devices still exist?

@ Switzerland

Indirect Democracy or Representative Democracy

7.What do you mean by Indirect Democracy or Representative Democracy

⚹ Representative Democracy is a system where citizens elect representatives to govern.

⚹ The form we know emerged in Europe during the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, notably driven by the rise of the British Parliament.

⚹ British parliamentary democracy gained strength through its conflicts with the monarchy, establishing a system where the government, a Council of Ministers, is collectively responsible to the Parliament.

⚹ Key milestones in its development include the establishment of adult franchise and civil rights.

⚹ The French Revolutionary ideals of Liberty, Equality, and Fraternity also made significant contributions to the core values of this democratic system.

8. Complete the table by comparing Direct Democracy with Indirect Democracy.

Direct Democracy	Indirect Democracy.
# The people rule directly. # High level of direct involvement by all eligible citizens. # Best suited for small communities or states with smaller populations (e.g., Ancient Athens, Swiss cantons). # Can be slow and time-consuming due to the need for mass participation and deliberation on every issue.	# The people rule through representatives. # Lower level of direct involvement; citizens primarily participate through elections. # Highly practical and necessary for large modern nation-states with millions of citizens (e.g., India, USA). # Generally more efficient and faster, as representatives can dedicate full time and expertise to governance.

Parliamentary System and Presidential System

9.Democratic systems are classified in this way based on the relationship between the executive branch and the legislature. Examine their features.

$ Features of the Parliamentary System

^ The executive branch is controlled by the legislature.The powers of the head of the state are nominal .

^ The head of state is the King/Queen/President.The head of government is the Prime Minister.

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^ The Prime Minister is the leader of the party that has the majority in the legislature.The council of ministers , headed by the Prime

^ Minister, is collectively responsible to the legislature

@ Features of the Presidential System

◊ The executive branch and the legislature are separate.

◊ The President serves both as the head of state and the head of government. All executive powers are vested in the President.

◊ The President is directly elected by the people.

◊ The President is not accountable to the legislature.

10.Prepare a note on the merits and demerits of the Parliamentary System

Merits	Demerits
* Harmony Between Executive and Legislature * Responsibility and Accountability * Flexibility * Better Representation	*Unstable Government * Tyranny of the Cabinet (or Party) * No Separation of Powers * Party Politics Dominance

11.Prepare a note on the merits and demerits of the Presidential System

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Merits	Demerits
Stable executive	Autocratic
Better policy implementation	Irresponsible
Direct reflection of people's choice	Lack of co-operation
Better administration	Lack of accountability

Basic Factors of a Democratic System

13.What are the basic factors of a Democratic System. Explain

? Freedom (Liberty), Equality, Justice, Rights, Rule of Law, Separation of Powers, Election and Representation, Secularism, Political Parties, Opposition

14.What is Freedom (Liberty) ?

• It is necessary factors for democracy to exist as a political and social order. Freedom is defined as the absence of restrictions.

•That is, a state devoid of any external restrictions on individuals. Freedom also has a creative dimension.

• In this sense, an opportunity to develop the capabilities of individuals can also be defined as freedom.

• The important freedoms are freedom to move, freedom to organise, freedom to assemble and freedom to express.

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• Of these, freedom to express serves as the foundation of democracy.

15.Differentiate Freedom and Restrictions.

e Freedom is not complete in the absence of restrictions.

e Therefore, some instructions and rules that individuals should and should not do are necessary for social life.

e It restricts the intrusion upon another person's freedom.

e The value of freedom becomes meaningful only in a system where each individual respects the freedom of others.

e The thought that one's own opinions and beliefs are more powerful than those of others leads to conflicts.

e In such cases, legal and political restrictions are needed.

16.What are the different ways that individuals use to express their ideas?

Conversation # Pictures # Social media posts # Trolls

17.What is meant by Equality?

⌘ Equality is a fundamental democratic value recognizing the inherent worth of all individuals and demanding the absence of discrimination based on factors like religion, gender, or race .

⌘ This principle underpins universal human rights.

⌘ Crucially, equality does not mean treating everyone identically; instead, it adopts a broader meaning by accommodating individual abilities or circumstances.

⌘ Therefore, acknowledging excellence, such as giving awards for achievements like a literature prize or a sports medal, is not a violation of equality.

18.Complete the table on the three Dimensions of Equality

Political Equality	Social Equality	Economic Equality
Right to vote Right to contest elections Right to hold public office	Non-discrimination Equal status Equal opportunities	Right to work Equal pay for equal work Right to leisure

19.Briefly explain Justice and the three Principles of Justice

⁂ Justice is one of the basic values of democracy.

⁂ The concept of justice changes over time.

⁂ In the modern view, justice means giving equal and due consideration to all individuals as human beings.

⁂ Three Principles of Justice

Recognition of Special Needs	Equal Treatment for Equals	Proportionate Justice
* In a society where inequality exists, the weaker section and the backward can enjoy equality only if special rights are granted * Methods such as reservation can be adopted to	* As human beings, all individuals deserve equal rights and equal consideration * No discrimination on the basis of class, caste, religion, gender, or race	* Justice should be proportionate to the ability and contribution of each person * Recognition of Special Needs * There is no injustice in

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ensure equality		treating each person separately according to their ability

20.Write a short note on rights

➢ Rights are fundamental to democracy and a dignified human existence. It distinguishes between a mere "claim" and a legally recognized "right."

➢ The text also notes that some thinkers believe in inherent "natural rights" (like life, liberty, and property) that predate the state.

➢ Many constitutions formally recognize these rights through a Bill of Rights, with Part III of the Indian Constitution serving as an example.

Different Types of Rights are

Political Rights	$ Right to vote $ Right to contest elections $ Right to hold public office $ Right to criticise the government
Civil Rights	$ Equality before the law $ Right to a free and fair trial $ Right to assemble and organise $ Freedom of expression
Economic Rights	$ Right to work $ Right to receive minimum wages $ Equal rights over the resources and property of the state
Cultural Rights	$ Right to preserve language and script $ Right to educate in the mother tongue $ Right of indigenous people to preserve their cultural heritage

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21.Elucidate the term Rule of Law

§ The rule of law is one of the basic values of democracy.

§ The essence of the rule of law is that everyone is equal before the law and everyone will receive equal legal protection.

§ The general laws of the country will apply equally to everyone.

§ There will be no special laws for any group.

§ Similarly, the government can fulfil its duties only through the process and principles prescribed by the legal system.

22.Briefly explain Separation of Powers

£ The separation of powers among the branches of government, namely the legislature, the executive, and the judiciary, is very important in a democratic system.

£ These three branches, while remaining independent in their respective areas, also check the activities of the other branches.

£ If all these powers are concentrated in a single branch, it will lead to tyranny and endanger the freedom and rights of the people.

23.What are the role of Election and Representation in the democratic system ?

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€ The modern democratic countries generally follow an indirect democratic system. In indirect democracy, the rule of the people means that the representatives of the people rule for the people.
€ Election is the system adopted to elect the representatives of the people.
€ Elections should be free, fair, and held at regular intervals.
€ For this, basic provisions regarding the right to vote and the conduct of elections should be included in the constitution of the country.
24."The basis of the concept of secularism is a clear separation between the state and religion" Evaluate the statement
₩ The state will not have an official religion.
₩ At the same time, citizens will have the freedom to believe in any religion they wish.
₩ The state will treat all religions equally.
₩ Since the state does not have an official religion, it does not discriminate against any community on the basis of religion.
₩ It provides citizens with equal justice and rights along with freedom of belief
25.Prepare a seminar on "The Role of Political Parties in Strengthening Democracy."
◎ Political parties are an essential element in a modern democracy.
◎ They play an important role in creating political awareness and shaping public opinion in a democracy.
◎ Political parties facilitate the functioning of a democracy.
◎ The conferences, marches and speeches they hold are the most powerful political education programmes in a democracy.
◎ The aim of political parties is to win elections and gain political power by turning public opinion in their favour.
26.Elucidate the Vital role the opposition plays in a democratic system?
✪ The opposition is crucial in a democracy, playing the important role of criticising and evaluating the government .
✪ Its freedom to act is a key indicator of a healthy democracy.
✪ A constructive opposition carefully scrutinises government activities, criticises wrong policies, and suggests alternative solutions based on public opinion.
✪ By organising marches and demonstrations, the opposition makes the political system dynamic and active.
✪ Conversely, any system that bans, restricts, or imprisons opposition leaders is detrimental to democratic health.
27.What are the factors that make the opposition essential in a democratic system?
@ Criticising and evaluating the government
@ Constructive Governance: Suggesting Alternatives
@ Dynamic System : Activation and Engagement
@ Ensures healthy democracy
28.There are also governments in the world that do not adhere to democracy. What are they ?

Monarchy	The oldest form of government. Power is transferred by inheritance All the power of the state is vested in the king/queen

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Dictatorship	All the powers of the state will be concentrated in one person. No one has the right to question or criticise the person who becomes the supreme leader of the state . All forms of democracy, including elections, will be banned.
Military Dictatorship	The military will rule directly . There will be no democratic rights or other forms of democracy . Protests and criticism will be suppressed by military force
Party Dictatorship	All the powers of the state are concentrated in the party. Democratic values, including freedom of expression, are completely prohibited
Theocratic State	Clergy will directly rule the state according to religious laws. The official religion of the state shall be the basis of the legal system. Everyone shall be obliged to believe in and follow the official religion.

Indian Democracy

29.Find and list out the reasons why India adopted a democratic system.

¢ Democratic values significantly shaped the Indian freedom struggle and its leaders, influencing the adoption of democratic methods in all movements .

¢ Recognizing India's vast cultural and geographical diversity, the leaders understood that only a democratic system could ensure political unity and provide a platform for diverse ideas to interact.

¢ Furthermore, the architects of independent India believed democracy was the sole system capable of ensuring peaceful power transfer and offering citizens a formal means to express grievances and protests.

¢ Consequently, upon achieving independence, India chose to implement a democratic system and drafted a corresponding constitution.

30.India is the largest democratic country in the world. Let us examine the features of Indian democracy.

Or

Organise a seminar on the features of the Indian democratic system.

☞ Parliamentary System ☞ Universal Adult Franchise in India ☞ Elected Government ☞ Independent Judiciary and Judicial Review ☞ Party System in India ☞ Pluralism

31.write a short Note on Parliamentary System

₹ In India's parliamentary system, the Council of Ministers, headed by the Prime Minister, wields the real power .

₹ This Council is characterized by its collective responsibility to Parliament.

₹ The Council can be removed if the Lok Sabha passes a no-confidence motion.

₹ Furthermore, Parliament maintains control over the Council of Ministers through various procedural mechanisms, including the Adjournment Motion, Question Hour, Calling-Attention Motion, and Zero Hour.

32.Prepare a discussion note on “The Importance of Universal Adult Franchise in

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Representative Democracy."

• The Indian Constitution, via Article 326, grants all citizens the right to vote regardless of caste, religion, gender, or class .

• While the initial voting age was 21, the 61st Constitutional Amendment reduced it to 18 years starting with the 1989 election.

• Despite initial opposition due to high illiteracy, Jawaharlal Nehru championed this right for all citizens.

• This adoption of universal adult franchise was highly significant because even advanced Western democracies initially restricted voting rights for workers and women, highlighting the progressive foresight of India's framers.

33.What do you mean by Elected Government ?

✪ India's government is formed by representatives elected by the people at the national and state levels .✪ These governments have a standard term of five years, after which new elections are held.

✪ Governing bodies for local self-government are also formed through elections.

✪ A fundamental democratic principle is that all Indian citizens are granted the right to contest elections and hold public office, regardless of caste, religion, gender, or economic status.

✪ To ensure the integrity of this process, an independent Election Commission conducts free and fair elections.

34.Prepare a short essay on Independent Judiciary and Judicial Review

* The Indian judicial system is structured with the Supreme Court at the apex, followed by the High Courts and lower courts .

* To ensure its necessary independence from the executive and legislature, judges are guaranteed a fixed tenure and the Constitution limits external interference in their service and salary conditions.

* The court functions as the guardian of the Constitution.

*Crucially, it possesses the power of judicial review, allowing it to declare any unconstitutional acts of the executive or legislature invalid.

35.Give an account on the Evolution of India's Party System in India

₩ Political parties are essential to India's democratic system, which has operated under a multi-party system since independence .

₩ From the initial elections until 1967, the Indian National Congress was dominant nationally.

₩ After this period, while Congress maintained national power, it began losing control in many states.

₩ A significant shift occurred after the 1989 elections, marking the introduction of the coalition system, where multiple parties cooperate to form the government.

36.Briefly explain Pluralism

§ Unlike the European nation-states based on "one culture, one nation," India was founded by giving equal rights and importance to its vast religious, ethnic, and cultural

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diversities .

§ To politically manage these differences, India adopted a federal system.

§ The Constitution specifically provides protection for religious and linguistic minorities through Fundamental Rights, includes 22 languages in the 8th Schedule, and offers special provisions for tribal groups in the 5th and 6th Schedules.

§ India is a secular state, as declared in its Preamble, meaning the nation has no official religion and treats all faiths equally.

§ The Indian Parliament serves as the representative forum for this entire national diversity

All the Very Best Dear Students

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